

Spotlight on Spinouts 2022

For the second year in a row, we've collaborated with The Royal Academy of Engineering to analyse trends in the UK's population of academic spinout companies.

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Royal Academy of Engineering

specialising in
Top investors into UK spinouts, by number of deals
and total value of deals
Survival and exit rates over the last 10 years

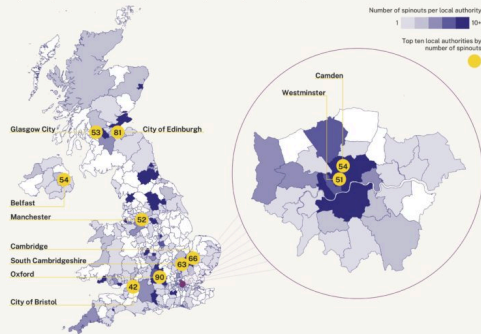
Here's a sneak peek inside

Top spinout clusters

The local authority hosting the most academic spinouts, Oxford (90) is home to the university with the highest count of spinouts, the University of Oxford. Similarly, the two Cambridgeshire local authorities – Cambridge and South Cambridgeshire – are headquarters for a combined 129 academic spinouts. This is caused by a large number of businesses choosing to headquarter their operations at a site close to their origin institution at the start of their journey. As these companies grow, however, many tend to migrate. Those that do relocate often move to London.

Another local authority where a large number of these businesses are headquartered is Edinburgh (81). Despite the nameake University only spinning out 58 businesses, the city has become a popular destination for companies to locate themselves once they have spun out from other institutions. For example, Beer 52 and Atrika are spinouts located in Edinburgh, despite having begun their journey at the University of Dundee and the University of Southampton, respectively. Other local authorities hosting a large number of spinouts include Belfast (54), Camden (54) and Glasgow City (53).

Map of top local authorities by number of spinouts (January 2022)



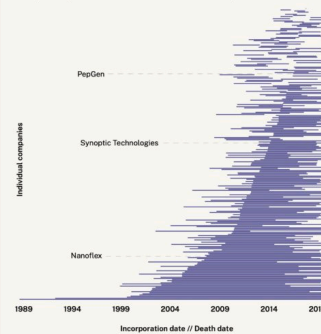
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Spinout survival rates

Of the 1,830 academic spinouts tracked by Beauhurst, 13.3% have died. But academic spinouts are more likely to survive than the average startup. Whilst only half of all startups will live longer than five years, the average age of death for an academic spinout is almost nine years. The cause of death for the 265 academic spinouts varies. The death of a company can be hard to predict, with the narrative of Synoptic Technologies exemplifying this. The business launched in 2015 as a University of Surrey spinout, quickly acquired their competitor Technotomy and secured £520k of equity investment. Despite this, the artificial intelligence marketing and sales platform died in 2019 – only four years later.

Whilst some spinouts die soon after their inception, most survive for several years – thus causing the average lifespan to be greater than that for all companies. Nanoflex, for example, ceased their operations in 2019 at the age of 11. The company manufactured non-electrodes for commercial purposes, to be used in technologies such as diabetic testing sensors and energy storage.

Lifespan of spinouts that have died since January 2012



8.80 years

Average age of UK spinouts at death (2012-2021)

265

Number of dead spinouts (January 2022)

19

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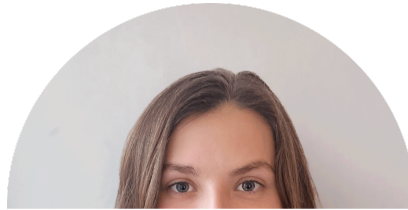
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Freya performs data analysis and visualisation in the Research & Consultancy team, with a focus on design, and has worked on projects for Barclays, EY and JP Morgan. She holds a BA in History (International) from the University of Leeds, which included a year at Fudan University in Shanghai.

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